



BOON: Democracy complements pluralism

is very difficult. A good example is the secession drive for Khalistan—the fact that the population of Punjab was so divided in terms of religion, class and economic well-being was an important factor in gutting the movement.

There is another way in which diversity promotes unity at this top level—by providing a tangible, flesh and blood 'Other'. Each group depends on this 'Other' to define itself, to reinforce its own identity. Muslims distinguish themselves from the idol-worshipping Hindus, Hindus from the beef-eating Muslims. Higher castes need the lower ones to set themselves apart from, through claims of being purer, more religious, more spiritually evolved, and so on. Punjabis wake up every morning and thank their stars they are not born Gujarati or Marathi or Sindhi or fill in the blank. Within the nervous system circuitry of each group is the realisation that to remain relevant, to perpetuate its very existence, the compressive force from this 'Other' is essential. Break off to strike out on your own, and there is no longer the pressure to bind the building block constituents together, there is no longer a *raison d'être*. It is therefore in each group's self-interest to maintain an equilibrium of two opposing actions. First, to draw their populations away from other groups by emphasising the differences, thus engendering internal solidarity. Simultaneously, to lean towards the same groups as a corrective measure, so that the mutually beneficial union (marked with no matter how much internecine hostility) is not completely destroyed.

One vital element not mentioned yet in this picture is democracy. This is the crucial release valve which stabilises the entire model. Disgruntled groups who feel they have been shortchanged know they have the opportunity to express their ire at the polls—they do not have to break away. It could be argued, therefore, that democracy is what really keeps the country intact—by enfranchising all individuals and

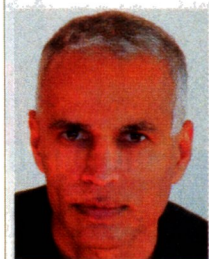
Disgruntled groups which have been short changed know they have the opportunity to express their ire at the polls. Therefore, democracy is what keeps the country intact.

groups, and providing them with a time-tested method of effecting change.

But suppose we delve a little deeper and ask why this form of government has worked so well in India. What gives Indian democracy its robustness, its longevity? As Edward Luce argues in his recent book, *In Spite of the Gods*, it is once again the diversity of the population that works behind the scenes to ensure democracy endures. The country, quite simply, is much too diverse for other forms of government to take root. "Far from endangering democracy, India's pluralism makes democracy essential," Luce writes. So even if we accept that democracy is one of the most important factors in fostering unity, we can still trace its continuing survival back to our old friend, diversity.

Sixty years ago, on the eve of Indian independence, Nehru made his famous "Tryst with Destiny" speech. "A new star arises, the star of freedom in the East," he declared, but it was actually millions of tiny stars that arose that evening; that, at the stroke of midnight, were launched into the sky and set free. The usual Newtonian rules of gravitation did not apply to these stars—instead, what kept them from flying apart on their own independent trajectories was a much more complex force field. A field which drew them together by pulling them apart, a field which depended on their very diversity to ensure unity.

In the first decade of this new millennium, it is important to remind ourselves of what continues to keeps India aloft—the millions of attractions and repulsions taking place between its multiplying stars, between the clusters and constellations they form, between its galaxies both massive and small. The Finnish model will never apply the romanticised ideal of all these components united in rosy, frictionless harmony. Rather, what's critical is to safeguard the rights, enfranchisement and continuing inclusion of each component, for the purely selfish reason of continued stability. Only then will India be assured of moving as one as it continues its cosmic voyage towards new trysts with destiny.



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